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MARSHALL, J., concurring in judgment

For these and other reasons,⁶ reliance on prosecutorial discretion, itself a fading talisman, to justify the unreviewability of agency inaction is inappropriate. See generally Stewart & Sunstein, Public Programs and Private Rights, 95 Harv. L. Rev. 1195, 1285-1286, n. 386 (1982) (discussing differences between agency inaction and prosecutorial discretion); Note, Judicial Review of Administrative Inaction, 83 Colum. L. Rev. 627, 658-661 (1983) (same). To the extent arguments about traditional notions of prosecutorial discretion have any force at all in this context, they ought to apply only

⁶Legal historians have suggested that the notion of prosecutorial discretion developed in England and America largely because private prosecutions were simultaneously available at the time. See Langbein, Controlling Prosecutorial Discretion in Germany, 41 U. Chi. L. Rev. 439, 443-446 (1974). Private enforcement of regulatory statutes, such as the FDCA, is of course largely unavailable.

In addition, scholars have noted that the tradition of unreviewability of prosecutor's decisions developed at a time when virtually all executive action was considered unreviewable. In asking what accounts for this "tradition," one scholar offered the following rhetorical questions:

"Is it because the tradition became settled during the nineteenth century when courts were generally assuming that judicial intrusion into any administration would be unfortunate? Is it because the tradition became settled while the Supreme Court was actuated by its 1840 remark that 'The interference of the Courts with the performance of the ordinary duties of the executive departments of the government, would be productive of nothing but mischief.' [citing *Decatur v. Paulding*, 14 Pet. 497, 516 (1840)]. Is it because the tradition became settled before the courts made the twentieth-century discovery that the courts can interfere with executive action to protect against abuses but at the same time can avoid taking over the executive function? Is it because the tradition became settled before the successes of the modern system of *limited* judicial review became fully recognized?

"On the basis of what the courts know today about leaving administration to administrators but at the same time providing an effective check to protect against abuses, should the courts not take a fresh look at the tradition that prevents them from reviewing the prosecuting function?" K. Davis, *Discretionary Justice* 211 (1969) (footnote omitted).

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to an agency's decision to decline to seek penalties against an individual for past conduct, not to a decision to refuse to investigate or take action on a public health, safety, or welfare problem.

II

The "tradition" of unreviewability upon which the majority relies is refuted most powerfully by a firmly entrenched body of lower court case law that holds reviewable various agency refusals to act.⁷ This case law recognizes that attempting to

⁷See, e. g., *Bargmann v. Helms*, 230 U. S. App. D. C. 164, 715 F. 2d 638 (1983); *Natural Resources Defense Council, Inc. v. EPA*, 683 F. 2d 752, 753, 767-768 (CA3 1982); *WWHT, Inc. v. FCC*, 211 U. S. App. D. C. 218, 656 F. 2d 807 (1981); *Carpet, Linoleum & Resilient Tile Layers, Local Union No. 419 v. Brown*, 656 F. 2d 564 (CA10 1981); *Natural Resources Defense Council, Inc. v. SEC*, 196 U. S. App. D. C. 124, 606 F. 2d 1031 (1979); *British Airways Board v. Port Authority of New York*, 564 F. 2d 1002, 1012-1013 (CA2 1977); *Pennsylvania v. National Assn. of Flood Insurers*, 520 F. 2d 11 (CA3 1975); *REA Express, Inc. v. CAB*, 507 F. 2d 42 (CA2 1974); *Davis v. Romney*, 490 F. 2d 1360 (CA3 1974); *Adams v. Richardson*, 156 U. S. App. D. C. 267, 480 F. 2d 1159 (1973) (en banc); *International Harvester Co. v. Ruckelshaus*, 155 U. S. App. D. C. 411, 478 F. 2d 615 (1973); *Rockbridge v. Lincoln*, 449 F. 2d 567 (CA9 1971); *Environmental Defense Fund, Inc. v. Ruckelshaus*, 142 U. S. App. D. C. 74, 439 F. 2d 584 (1971); *Environmental Defense Fund, Inc. v. Hardin*, 138 U. S. App. D. C. 391, 428 F. 2d 1093 (1970); *Medical Committee for Human Rights v. SEC*, 139 U. S. App. D. C. 226, 432 F. 2d 659 (1970), vacated as moot, 404 U. S. 403 (1972); *Trailways of New England, Inc. v. CAB*, 412 F. 2d 926 (CA1 1969); *International Union, United Auto., Aero. & Agric. Implement Workers v. NLRB*, 427 F. 2d 1330 (CA6 1970); *Public Citizen Health Research Group v. Auchter*, 554 F. Supp. 242 (DC 1983), rev'd in part, 226 U. S. App. D. C. 413, 702 F. 2d 1150 (1983); *Sierra Club v. Gorsuch*, 551 F. Supp. 785 (ND Cal. 1982); *Hoffmann-LaRoche, Inc. v. Weinberger*, 425 F. Supp. 890 (DC 1975); *NAACP v. Levi*, 418 F. Supp. 1109 (DC 1976); *Guerrero v. Garza*, 418 F. Supp. 182 (WD Wis. 1976); *Souder v. Brennan*, 367 F. Supp. 808, 811 (DC 1973); *City-Wide Coalition Against Childhood Lead Paint Poisoning v. Philadelphia Housing Auth.*, 356 F. Supp. 123 (ED Pa. 1973); *American Public Health Assn. v. Vene-man*, 349 F. Supp. 1311 (DC 1972).

To be sure, some of these cases involved the refusal to initiate rule-making proceedings, and the majority expressly disavows any claim that